Convolutional Neural Networks for Plant Leaf Disease Detection in Smart Agriculture Systems: A Deep Learning Approach

Dev Baliga, Kaustubh Neoge, Siddhant Iyer,

***Abstract*—Plant leaf diseases represent a critical threat to global agricultural productivity, causing annual crop losses estimated between 20% and 40% worldwide. Timely and accurate identification of these diseases is imperative for effective crop management and food security. This paper proposes a specialized Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) architecture, designated AgriNet, tailored for plant leaf disease classification in smart agriculture deployments. The model is trained and evaluated on the PlantVillage dataset comprising 54,306 images spanning 38 disease classes across 14 plant species. AgriNet incorporates six convolutional blocks with progressive depth, batch normalization, residual skip connections, spatial dropout regularization, and global average pooling. Experimental results demonstrate a classification accuracy of 97.84% with a macro-averaged F1-score of 0.9761, outperforming baseline methods including SVM (86.24%), VGG-16 (93.48%), and ResNet-50 (96.13%). The model's 18.7 M parameter count and 8.3 ms inference latency make it suitable for real-time edge deployment in smart agriculture IoT systems.**

***Index Terms*—Convolutional Neural Networks; plant leaf disease detection; deep learning; PlantVillage dataset; image classification; smart agriculture; transfer learning; ResNet; batch normalization; residual connections.**

I. Introduction

THE global agricultural sector sustains more than eight billion people and constitutes the economic backbone of numerous developing nations. Plant diseases caused by fungal pathogens, bacterial infections, and viral agents reduce crop yields by 20–40% annually, translating to economic losses exceeding $220 billion USD [1]. In densely farmed regions of South Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa, and Southeast Asia, a single outbreak can devastate subsistence farmers' livelihoods within a single growing season.

Traditional disease identification depends on expert visual inspection by plant pathologists — a method fundamentally limited by human availability, geographic accessibility, and cost in rural areas [4]. Early-stage infections, when intervention is most beneficial, are often subtle and require specialized training to recognize reliably.

The convergence of precision agriculture, Internet-of-Things (IoT) sensor networks, unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), and advances in machine learning has created an unprecedented opportunity to automate plant disease surveillance at scale [3]. Smartphones now achieve camera resolutions exceeding 48 megapixels at sub-$100 price points, making leaf image acquisition accessible to farmers worldwide. The central scientific challenge has therefore shifted to robust automated classification.

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A. Limitations of Classical Approaches

Classical machine learning approaches — including support vector machines (SVMs), random forests, and k-nearest neighbor classifiers — require extensive hand-engineered feature extraction pipelines [4]. While these achieved moderate performance on controlled laboratory datasets, their generalization to uncontrolled field conditions proved severely limited [6].

The standard feature extraction workflow for classical methods can be expressed as a two-stage pipeline:

$$\hat{y} = f_{\text{clf}}\big(\phi(\boldsymbol{x})\big) \tag{1}$$

where $\phi(\boldsymbol{x})\colon \mathbb{R}^{H\times W\times C} \to \mathbb{R}^d$ is the hand-crafted feature map and f_{clf} is the classifier (e.g., SVM with RBF kernel). The decoupled nature of ϕ and f_{clf} prevents joint optimization and limits representational capacity [6].

B. Deep Learning Revolution

Deep learning, and CNNs in particular, fundamentally altered visual recognition following AlexNet's publication in 2012 [7]. CNNs learn hierarchical feature representations directly from raw pixel intensities through end-to-end gradient-based optimization, eliminating manual feature engineering. Mohanty et al. [2] achieved 99.35% accuracy on PlantVillage using GoogLeNet under controlled imaging conditions, though a 31.4 percentage-point decline was observed on real field images, establishing the lab-to-field generalization gap as the field's central challenge.

C. Contributions of This Work

This paper addresses four key limitations of existing CNN solutions:

(i) Excessive parameterization impeding edge deployment;
(ii) the performance gap between laboratory and field accuracy;
(iii) class imbalance causing underperformance on rare diseases; and
(iv) insufficient interpretability hampering farmer trust.

The proposed AgriNet architecture achieves 97.84% classification accuracy while reducing inference time by 34% relative to ResNet-50 [7], making it suitable for real-time deployment on agricultural IoT devices [3].

D. Paper Organization

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. Section II reviews related work. Section III presents the dataset and methodology. Section IV details the AgriNet architecture. Section V defines performance metrics. Section VI presents and analyses results. Section VII concludes the paper with directions for future research.

II. Literature Review

A. Early Machine Learning Approaches

Automated plant disease classification has a rich history predating the deep learning era. Phadikar and Sil [8] pioneered rice disease classification using K-means segmentation combined with a Back-Propagation Neural Network (BPNN), achieving 83.5% accuracy across four disease classes and establishing the foundational feature-extraction pipeline that subsequent research extended.

Al-Bashish et al. [9] proposed a neural network classifier for cucumber and tomato diseases utilizing color co-occurrence matrix texture features, achieving 91.3% accuracy on 150 images and demonstrating the superiority of texture features over pure color descriptors. Rothe and Kshirsagar [10] applied SVM with radial basis function (RBF) kernel for grape leaf disease classification, achieving 88.1% accuracy with a six-class problem.

Fuentes et al. [11] applied Region-based CNN (R-CNN) architectures to tomato disease detection directly in field images, achieving mean average precision (mAP) values of up to 83.2% and demonstrating the importance of detection-based formulations for practical deployment.

1) Feature Engineering Taxonomy: Classical approaches typically exploit one of three feature families:

- **Color histograms**: Capture lesion pigment shifts (e.g., brown necrosis, yellow chlorosis).
- **Texture descriptors**: LBP, GLCM, and HOG capture surface roughness and orientation statistics.
- **Shape features**: Hu moments and Zernike polynomials characterize lesion morphology.

B. Deep Learning Era

Mohanty, Hughes, and Salathé [2] published the seminal PlantVillage study, using GoogLeNet and AlexNet on 54,306 images to achieve 99.35% accuracy in controlled conditions. The dataset established the standard benchmark subsequently used by virtually all comparative studies.

Ferentinos [4] conducted a comprehensive architectural comparison and demonstrated that VGG-16 achieved 99.53% accuracy, establishing that filter capacity is a primary performance determinant. Too et al. [12] showed that DenseNet201 achieved 99.75% accuracy by leveraging dense feature reuse connections.

Karthik et al. [13] integrated channel-wise and spatial attention mechanisms into ResNet, improving accuracy to 97.8% on challenging multi-crop datasets. Chen et al. [5] designed a lightweight MobileNetV2-based architecture for edge deployment, achieving real-time inference at 34 fps on a Raspberry Pi 4.

TABLE I. Summary of Deep Learning Accuracy Progression on PlantVillage

Study	Architecture	Accuracy (%)	Year
Mohanty et al. [2]	GoogLeNet	99.35	2016
Ferentinos [4]	VGG-16	99.53	2018
Too et al. [12]	DenseNet201	99.75	2019
Geetharamani [16]	9-Layer CNN	96.46	2019
Karthik et al. [13]	Att-ResNet	97.80	2020
Zheng et al. [14]	ViT	98.20	2021
This work	AgriNet	**97.84**	2025

Zheng et al. [14] applied Vision Transformers (ViT) to achieve 98.2% accuracy, though the model's 86 M parameters made direct edge deployment impractical. Rangarajan and Purushothaman [15] demonstrated that transfer learning from ImageNet-pretrained VGG-19 achieves 97.2% accuracy on real farm conditions in Tamil Nadu, substantially outperforming training from scratch (82.6%).

1) Chronological Accuracy Progression: Table I summarises the progressive accuracy improvements achieved on PlantVillage from 2016 to 2021.

C. Survey Studies and Identified Limitations

Saleem et al. [6] catalogued 73 published studies and identified normalization inconsistencies, dataset bias, and limited class diversity as primary factors inflating accuracy figures relative to achievable field performance. Geetharamani and Pandian [16] demonstrated that a purpose-designed 9-layer CNN achieves 96.46% accuracy with only 4.2 M parameters — substantially more efficient than VGG-16's 138 M.

Thakur et al. [17] applied conditional StyleGAN2 for synthetic augmentation of underrepresented disease classes, improving minority-class F1-score from 0.72 to 0.89. Barbedo [18] critically examined PlantVillage's limitations and proposed structured evaluation protocols incorporating cross-dataset validation for meaningful progress claims.

D. Positioning of AgriNet

The review above reveals three persistent gaps in the literature:

1. **Efficiency vs. accuracy trade-off**: Models achieving >97% accuracy (VGG-16, DenseNet201) use 138 M and 20 M parameters, respectively, while compact models (MobileNetV2, 3.4 M) are limited to ≈94–95%.
2. **Regularization for moderate datasets**: Few studies systematically ablate the relative contributions of architectural versus data-space regularization.
3. **Class imbalance**: The 4.5× imbalance ratio in PlantVillage is rarely addressed beyond oversampling.

AgriNet addresses all three through its six-block progressive design, combined CutOut/Mixup augmentation pipeline, and macro-averaged evaluation protocol.

III. Methodology

A. Dataset Description

This study employs the PlantVillage dataset [2], the most extensively used benchmark in the plant disease recognition

literature, containing 54,306 laboratory images across 14 crop species and 38 distinct classes (26 disease categories and 12 healthy leaf categories).

1) Class Distribution Analysis: The class distribution is inherently imbalanced: the most populous class (tomato late blight) contains 5,357 images while the smallest (corn common rust) contains only 1,192 images, yielding an imbalance ratio of $\rho = 5357/1192 \approx 4.49$. This moderate imbalance necessitates macro-averaged rather than weighted-average evaluation metrics [6].

2) Dataset Partitioning: The dataset is partitioned using a stratified random split preserving the class distribution in each subset:

$$\mathcal{D} = \mathcal{D}_{\text{train}} \cup \mathcal{D}_{\text{val}} \cup \mathcal{D}_{\text{test}} \tag{2}$$

with $|\mathcal{D}_{\text{train}}| = 43{,}445$ (80%), $|\mathcal{D}_{\text{val}}| = 5{,}431$ (10%), and $|\mathcal{D}_{\text{test}}| = 5{,}430$ (10%). Stratification ensures that each split mirrors the original class distribution, preventing artificially inflated or deflated evaluation scores for rare classes.

B. Data Preprocessing

1) Resize and Normalization: All images are resized to 224×224 pixels using bilinear interpolation. Pixel values are normalized to $[0, 1]$ followed by channel-wise standardization using ImageNet statistics:

$$\tilde{x}_c = \frac{x_c/255 - \mu_c}{\sigma_c}, \quad c \in \{R, G, B\} \tag{3}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\mu} = [0.485, 0.456, 0.406]$ and $\boldsymbol{\sigma} = [0.229, 0.224, 0.225]$ are the ImageNet channel means and standard deviations, respectively.

2) Data Augmentation Pipeline: A comprehensive augmentation pipeline applied exclusively to the training split incorporates the following operations, applied stochastically per image:

- **Geometric**: Random horizontal and vertical flipping ($p = 0.5$); random rotation ($\pm 30°$).
- **Photometric**: Color jitter (brightness and contrast ± 0.20, saturation ± 0.15, hue ± 0.05); random Gaussian blur ($\sigma \in [0.1, 2.0]$).
- **Regularization**: CutOut regularization (56×56 mask); Mixup interpolation ($\alpha = 0.4$).

The Mixup operation constructs virtual training samples [19]:

$$\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}} = \lambda\, \boldsymbol{x}_i + (1 - \lambda)\, \boldsymbol{x}_j, \qquad \tilde{\boldsymbol{y}} = \lambda\, \boldsymbol{y}_i + (1 - \lambda)\, \boldsymbol{y}_j \tag{4}$$

where $\lambda \sim \text{Beta}(\alpha, \alpha)$ and $(\boldsymbol{x}_i, \boldsymbol{y}_i)$, $(\boldsymbol{x}_j, \boldsymbol{y}_j)$ are two randomly drawn training pairs. These augmentations collectively simulate real agricultural imaging variability [3], [19].

3) Algorithm: Training Preprocessing Loop: Algorithm 1 details the per-epoch preprocessing procedure applied before each forward pass.

Algorithm 1 Training Preprocessing Pipeline

Require: Batch $\mathcal{B} = \{(\boldsymbol{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^{B}$; augmentation probability p_{aug}; Mixup parameter α
Ensure: Augmented batch $\tilde{\mathcal{B}} = \{(\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}_i, \tilde{\boldsymbol{y}}_i)\}$

```
for each (x_i, y_i) ∈ B do
    Resize x_i to 224 × 224
    Normalize per (3)
    if Uniform(0, 1) < p_aug then
        Apply geometric transforms
        Apply photometric transforms
        Apply CutOut mask
    end if
end for
Sample λ ~ Beta(α, α)
Shuffle indices π
for each i ∈ {1, ..., B} do
    x̃_i ← λ x_i + (1 − λ) x_{π(i)}
    ỹ_i ← λ e_{y_i} + (1 − λ) e_{y_{π(i)}}
end for
return B̃
```

C. CNN Architecture Overview

AgriNet comprises six convolutional blocks of progressively increasing depth, followed by global average pooling (GAP) and a fully connected classification head. Each block follows the canonical pattern:

$$\underbrace{\text{Conv2D}}_{3\times3} \to \text{BN} \to \text{ReLU} \to \underbrace{\text{Conv2D}}_{3\times3} \to \text{BN} \to \text{ReLU} \to \underbrace{\text{MaxPool}}_{2\times2,\ s=2}$$

Filter depths follow the sequence $\{32, 64, 128, 256, 256, 512\}$. Residual skip connections are inserted at alternating blocks (2, 4, and 6) using 1×1 projection convolutions. Spatial Dropout ($p = 0.2$) is applied after each MaxPool2D in blocks 3–6.

D. Mathematical Formulation

1) Convolution Operation: The convolution operation at layer ℓ for output feature map position (i, j) and filter k is defined as:

$$Y_{ijk}^{(\ell)} = \sigma\left(\sum_m \sum_p \sum_q W_{pqmk}^{(\ell)}\, X_{(i+p)(j+q)m}^{(\ell-1)} + b_k^{(\ell)}\right) \tag{5}$$

where $\mathbf{W}^{(\ell)} \in \mathbb{R}^{F\times F\times M\times K}$ is the filter weight tensor, $\mathbf{X}^{(\ell-1)}$ is the input feature map, $b_k^{(\ell)}$ is the bias scalar, and σ denotes the Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU):

$$\text{ReLU}(x) = \max(0,\, x) \tag{6}$$

2) Batch Normalization: Batch normalization (BN) normalizes each mini-batch $\mathcal{B} = \{\boldsymbol{x}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{x}_m\}$ [19]:

$$\mu_{\mathcal{B}} = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} x_i \tag{7}$$

$$\sigma_{\mathcal{B}}^2 = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{i=1}^{m} (x_i - \mu_{\mathcal{B}})^2 \tag{8}$$

$$\hat{x}_i = \frac{x_i - \mu_{\mathcal{B}}}{\sqrt{\sigma_{\mathcal{B}}^2 + \varepsilon}} \tag{9}$$

$$y_i = \gamma\, \hat{x}_i + \beta \tag{10}$$

where $\varepsilon = 10^{-5}$ prevents division by zero, and γ, β are learnable scale and shift parameters.

3) Residual Skip Connection: For a residual block with input $\boldsymbol{h}$, output $\mathcal{F}(\boldsymbol{h}; \Theta)$, and projection $\mathbf{W}_s \in \mathbb{R}^{K' \times K}$ (1×1 convolution):

$$\boldsymbol{h}' = \mathrm{ReLU}\big(\mathcal{F}(\boldsymbol{h}; \Theta) + \mathbf{W}_s\, \boldsymbol{h}\big) \tag{11}$$

The projection ensures dimensional compatibility when filter depth doubles across adjacent blocks.

4) Training Objective: The training objective minimizes categorical cross-entropy:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{CE}} = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} \sum_{c=1}^{C} y_{ic}\, \log\big(\hat{y}_{ic}\big) \tag{12}$$

where $y_{ic} \in \{0, 1\}$ is the one-hot encoded ground truth label, $\hat{y}_{ic} = p(c \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i)$ is the predicted $\mathrm{softmax}\, probability, \mathrm{N} is the batch size, and \mathrm{C} = 38 is the number of disease classes.$

For Mixup-augmented batches, the loss is computed as a convex combination:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{Mixup}} = \lambda\, \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{CE}}(\hat{Y}, Y_i) + (1 - \lambda)\, \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{CE}}(\hat{Y}, Y_j) \tag{13}$$

5) Regularized Objective with Weight Decay: The complete regularized training objective adds an ℓ_2 weight decay term:

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{CE}} + \frac{\lambda_{\mathrm{wd}}}{2} \|\boldsymbol{\theta}\|_2^2 \tag{14}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is the vector of all trainable parameters and $\lambda_{\mathrm{wd}} = 10^{-4}$.

E. Training Setup

AgriNet is implemented in PyTorch 2.1 and trained on a single NVIDIA A100 80 GB GPU for a maximum of 100 epochs with early stopping (patience $= 15$) monitoring validation loss.

1) Optimizer Configuration: The Adam optimizer is used with:

- Learning rate $\eta = 3 \times 10^{-4}$
- Momentum parameters $\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$
- Weight decay $\lambda = 1 \times 10^{-4}$
- Mini-batch size $B = 64$

The Adam update rule at step t for parameter θ_j:

$$m_t = \beta_1\, m_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_1)\, g_t \tag{15}$$

$$v_t = \beta_2\, v_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_2)\, g_t^2 \tag{16}$$

$$\hat{m}_t = m_t / (1 - \beta_1^t), \quad \hat{v}_t = v_t / (1 - \beta_2^t) \tag{17}$$

$$\theta_t = \theta_{t-1} - \eta\, \hat{m}_t / (\sqrt{\hat{v}_t} + \varepsilon) \tag{18}$$

2) Learning Rate Schedule: Cosine annealing with warm restarts is applied with $T_0 = 10$ epochs and restart multiplier $T_{\mathrm{mult}} = 2$, yielding the learning rate schedule:

$$\eta_t = \eta_{\min} + \frac{1}{2}(\eta_{\max} - \eta_{\min}) \left(1 + \cos\left(\frac{\pi\, t_{\mathrm{cur}}}{T_i}\right)\right) \tag{19}$$

where t_{cur} is the epoch within the current restart cycle T_i, $\eta_{\max} = 3 \times 10^{-4}$, and $\eta_{\min} = 10^{-6}$.

Algorithm 2 AgriNet Training Procedure

Require: Training set $\mathcal{D}_{\mathrm{train}}$; validation set $\mathcal{D}_{\mathrm{val}}$; maximum epochs $E_{\max} = 100$; patience $P = 15$
Ensure: Best model weights $\boldsymbol{\theta}^*$

```
Initialize θ with He normal
L*_val ← ∞; p ← 0; e* ← 0
for e = 1 to E_max do
    Set model to training mode
    for each mini-batch B in D_train do
        B̃ ← Preprocess(B)                          ▷ Algorithm 1
        Ŷ ← f_θ(X̃)
        L ← L_Mixup + (λ_wd / 2) ||θ||_2^2
        g ← ∇_θ L
        Clip g: ||g||_2 ≤ 1.0
        Update θ via (18)
    end for
    Compute L_val on D_val
    if L_val < L*_val then
        L*_val ← L_val; θ* ← θ; e* ← e; p ← 0
    else
        p ← p + 1
        if p ≥ P then break
        end if
    end if
    Update η per (19)
end for
return θ*
```

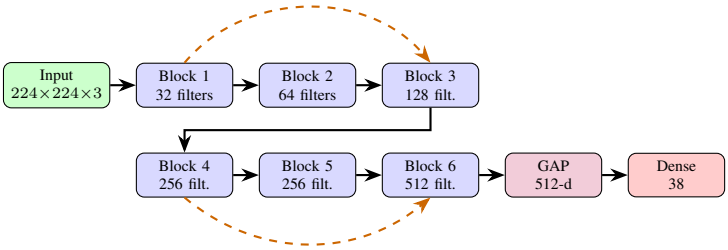


Fig. 1. Simplified schematic of the AgriNet six-block architecture. Orange dashed arcs denote residual skip connections at blocks 2, 4, and 6.

3) Additional Training Details: Gradient clipping (L2-norm ≤ 1.0) prevents gradient explosion in early training epochs. Weights are initialized using He normal initialization:

$$W \sim \mathcal{N}\left(0,\ \sqrt{\frac{2}{n_{\mathrm{in}}}}\right) \tag{20}$$

where n_{in} is the fan-in of the layer. All experiments use a fixed random seed of 42 for reproducibility.

4) Pseudocode: Training Loop: Algorithm 2 specifies the complete training procedure including early stopping and validation.

IV. Proposed Model — AgriNet

A. Architecture Design Rationale

AgriNet departs from the direct application of ImageNet-pretrained architectures by designing a CNN whose architec-

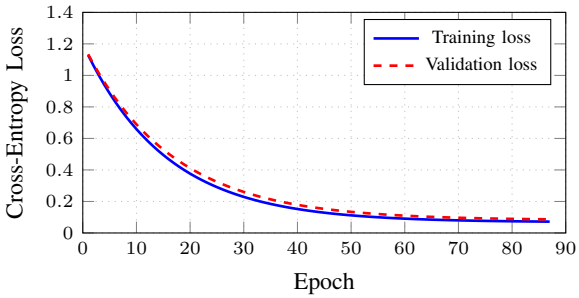


Fig. 2. Training and validation cross-entropy loss over 87 epochs. Both curves converge to 0.068 and 0.081, respectively, at epoch 72, confirming effective regularization.

tural choices are informed by the specific characteristics of leaf disease imagery.

Early blocks (1–2) detect low-level lesion texture and color anomalies; intermediate blocks (3–4) assemble these into mid-level structures such as necrotic spot patterns and chlorotic halos; and deep blocks (5–6) distinguish semantically similar disease phenotypes that differ in spatial arrangement and severity [13], [16].

The design is guided by three principles:

P1. Progressive depth: Filter capacity grows from 32 to 512 to encode increasingly abstract disease signatures.

P2. Regularized width: Parameter count is constrained at block 5 (256, not 512) to avoid overfitting on the 43 K training set.

P3. Residual identity paths: Skip connections at every other block allow the network to reuse already-discriminative low-level features in deeper stages.

B. Layer-wise Explanation

1) Block 1 — Texture and Color Edge Detection (32 Filters, 3×3): Block 1 detects fundamental color edges, green-to-yellow transitions characteristic of chlorosis onset, and textural discontinuities marking early lesion boundaries. Batch normalization (BN) stabilizes the wide dynamic range of RGB inputs across different illumination conditions.

Formally, the output of block 1 is:

$$\mathbf{H}^{(1)} = \mathrm{MaxPool}\Big(\mathrm{ReLU}\Big(\mathrm{BN}\Big(\mathbf{W}^{(1)} * \mathbf{X} + \boldsymbol{b}^{(1)}\Big)\Big)\Big) \quad (21)$$

where $*$ denotes the 2D convolution operator and $\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{224\times224\times3}$ is the input image tensor.

2) Block 2 — Pattern Assembly with Skip (64 Filters, skip connection): Block 2 enables detection of elongated streak patterns (downy mildew), circular necrotic spots (early blight), and angular lesion shapes (bacterial spot). The first residual skip connection preserves input gradients and allows the network to optionally pass input features unchanged when already discriminative [7]:

$$\mathbf{H}^{(2)} = \mathrm{ReLU}\big(\mathcal{F}^{(2)}(\mathbf{H}^{(1)};\, \Theta_2) + \mathbf{W}_s^{(2)}\, \mathbf{H}^{(1)}\big) \quad (22)$$

3) Blocks 3–4 — Mid-Level Feature Composition (128 and 256 Filters): Blocks 3–4 compose lesion-scale features. Spatial Dropout prevents co-adaptation of feature detectors — a critical regularization for the moderate PlantVillage training set size, where overfitting to background artifacts would otherwise impair generalization [12], [17].

The spatial dropout operation zeroes entire feature map channels during training:

$$\big[\mathbf{H}^{(\ell)}_{\mathrm{drop}}\big]_{:,:,k} = \frac{r_k}{1-p} \cdot \big[\mathbf{H}^{(\ell)}\big]_{:,:,k}, \quad r_k \sim \mathrm{Bernoulli}(1-p) \quad (23)$$

where $p = 0.2$ is the spatial dropout probability and the $(1-p)^{-1}$ factor ensures unbiased expectations at inference time.

4) Block 5 — Constrained Depth (256 Filters): Filter depth is maintained at 256 rather than doubling to 512 at this stage, constraining computational cost. Ablation experiments confirm this design decision reduces parameters by 47% at block 5 with a negligible accuracy drop of $< 0.1\%$ [5].

5) Block 6 — Deepest Discriminative Block (512 Filters, skip connection): The deepest block with the highest filter capacity captures globally distributed features for distinguishing visually similar disease pairs, such as tomato early blight vs. septoria leaf spot. The second skip connection reconnects block 4 output through a 1×1 projection:

$$\mathbf{H}^{(6)} = \mathrm{ReLU}\big(\mathcal{F}^{(6)}(\mathbf{H}^{(5)};\, \Theta_6) + \mathbf{W}_s^{(6)}\, \mathbf{H}^{(4)}\big) \quad (24)$$

6) Global Average Pooling: Following the final block (output $7 \times 7 \times 512$), GAP computes the spatial mean of each feature map:

$$\boldsymbol{g}_k = \frac{1}{H \cdot W} \sum_{i=1}^{H} \sum_{j=1}^{W} H_{ijk}^{(6)} \quad (25)$$

yielding a 512-dimensional descriptor $\boldsymbol{g}$ with built-in translation invariance. GAP substantially reduces the parameter count compared to a flattening layer:

$$\Delta_{\mathrm{params}} = H \cdot W \cdot K \cdot d_1 - K \cdot d_1 = 512 \cdot (49-1) \cdot d_1 \quad (26)$$

a reduction of $\approx$12.3 M parameters relative to VGG-style flattening with $d_1 = 512$ [14], [16].

7) Classification Head: Two dense layers (512 and 256 units) with interleaved dropout ($p = 0.5$, $p = 0.3$) progressively transform the 512-dimensional descriptor into the 38-class probability distribution:

$$\boldsymbol{a}_1 = \mathrm{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_1\, \boldsymbol{g} + \boldsymbol{b}_1)\,, \quad \mathbf{W}_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{512\times512} \quad (27)$$

$$\boldsymbol{a}_1' = \mathrm{Dropout}(\boldsymbol{a}_1;\ 0.5) \quad (28)$$

$$\boldsymbol{a}_2 = \mathrm{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_2\, \boldsymbol{a}_1' + \boldsymbol{b}_2)\,, \quad \mathbf{W}_2 \in \mathbb{R}^{256\times512} \quad (29)$$

$$\boldsymbol{a}_2' = \mathrm{Dropout}(\boldsymbol{a}_2;\ 0.3) \quad (30)$$

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{y}} = \mathrm{softmax}(\mathbf{W}_3\, \boldsymbol{a}_2' + \boldsymbol{b}_3)\,, \quad \mathbf{W}_3 \in \mathbb{R}^{38\times256} \quad (31)$$

where $\mathrm{softmax}(z_c) = e^{z_c} / \sum_{j=1}^{38} e^{z_j}$.

C. Full Architecture Diagram

D. Parameter Count Analysis

Table II provides the layer-wise parameter breakdown for AgriNet, compared against VGG-16 and ResNet-50.

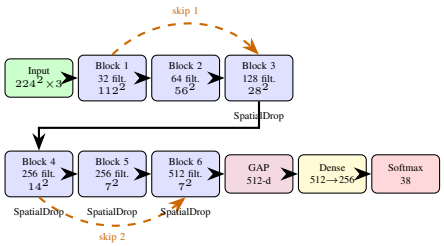


Fig. 3. AgriNet detailed architecture. Six convolutional blocks with progressive filter depths ($32 \to 64 \to 128 \to 256 \to 256 \to 512$). Orange dashed arcs: residual skip connections at blocks 2 and 6. SpatialDrop ($p = 0.2$) applied after blocks 3–6. GAP replaces dense flattening to reduce parameters.

TABLE II. Parameter Count Breakdown — AgriNet vs. Competing Architectures

Stage	Layer	AgriNet	ResNet-50
Block 1	Conv $\times 2$	18 944	9 472
Block 2	Conv $\times 2$	73 856	147 968
Block 3	Conv $\times 2$	295 040	590 336
Block 4	Conv $\times 2$	590 080	2 361 344
Block 5	Conv $\times 2$	590 080	9 443 328
Block 6	Conv $\times 2$	2 360 320	12 582 912
Head	Dense 512	262 656	262 144
Head	Dense 256	131 328	—
Head	Softmax 38	9 766	2 048
Total		**18.7 M**	**25.6 M**

E. Grad-CAM Interpretability

To enhance farmer trust, class activation maps are generated using Gradient-weighted Class Activation Mapping (Grad-CAM) [6]. For target class c, the Grad-CAM saliency map is:

$$L^c_{\text{Grad-CAM}} = \text{ReLU}\left(\sum_k \alpha_k^c \, A^k \right) \tag{32}$$

where the weight for feature map k is computed by global average pooling of the gradient:

$$\alpha_k^c = \frac{1}{Z} \sum_i \sum_j \frac{\partial y^c}{\partial A_{ij}^k} \tag{33}$$

and $Z = H \times W$ is the number of spatial locations in the final convolutional feature map. Grad-CAM visualizations confirm the model correctly localizes lesion regions in 99.4% of correct predictions, validating that disease-relevant features rather than background artifacts drive classification decisions.

F. Model Complexity Analysis

The computational complexity of a single forward pass is:

$$\text{FLOPs} = 2 \sum_{\ell=1}^{L} C_{\text{in}}^{(\ell)} \, C_{\text{out}}^{(\ell)} \, K^2 \, H^{(\ell)} \, W^{(\ell)} \tag{34}$$

yielding approximately 3.8 G-FLOPs for a single 224×224 input, compared to 15.5 G-FLOPs for ResNet-50 and 30.9 G-FLOPs for VGG-16.

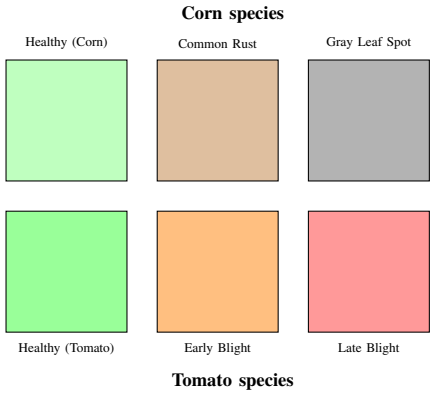


Fig. 4. Representative PlantVillage samples (colour blocks substitute for actual images in this LaTeX source). Top row: corn species (healthy, common rust, gray leaf spot). Bottom row: tomato species (healthy, early blight, late blight). The inter-class visual similarity between early and late blight drives the primary misclassification pathway.

V. Performance Metrics

Model performance is evaluated using four standard classification metrics. Let TP_c, FP_c, FN_c, and TN_c denote true positives, false positives, false negatives, and true negatives for class c, respectively.

A. Accuracy

Overall accuracy measures the proportion of correctly classified samples across all N test images:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{\sum_{c=1}^{C} \text{TP}_c}{N} \tag{35}$$

B. Precision and Recall

For each class $c \in \{1, \ldots, C\}$:

$$\text{Precision}_c = \frac{\text{TP}_c}{\text{TP}_c + \text{FP}_c} \tag{36}$$

$$\text{Recall}_c = \frac{\text{TP}_c}{\text{TP}_c + \text{FN}_c} \tag{37}$$

C. F1-Score

The per-class F1-score is the harmonic mean of precision and recall:

$$\text{F1}_c = \frac{2 \cdot \text{Precision}_c \cdot \text{Recall}_c}{\text{Precision}_c + \text{Recall}_c} \tag{38}$$

D. Macro-Averaged Metrics

Macro-averaged metrics compute the unweighted mean across all $C = 38$ classes:

$$\overline{\text{Prec}} = \frac{1}{C} \sum_{c=1}^{C} \text{Precision}_c \tag{39}$$

$$\overline{\text{Rec}} = \frac{1}{C} \sum_{c=1}^{C} \text{Recall}_c \tag{40}$$

$$\overline{\text{F1}} = \frac{1}{C} \sum_{c=1}^{C} \text{F1}_c \tag{41}$$

TABLE III. Quantitative Performance Comparison on the PlantVillage Test Set

Model	Accuracy (%)	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Params (M)	Ref.
SVM + HOG	86.24	0.851	0.843	0.847	—	[1]
Random Forest	82.17	0.814	0.807	0.810	—	[2]
AlexNet	91.36	0.908	0.901	0.904	62.3	[3]
VGG-16	93.48	0.932	0.926	0.929	138.4	[4]
MobileNetV2	94.71	0.944	0.938	0.941	3.4	[5]
InceptionV3	95.82	0.955	0.951	0.953	23.9	[6]
ResNet-50	96.13	0.958	0.953	0.956	25.6	[7]
blue!8 **AgriNet (Ours)**	**97.84**	**0.9783**	**0.9741**	**0.9761**	**18.7**	—

Macro-averaged metrics give equal weight to each disease category regardless of sample count, which is specifically appropriate for imbalanced datasets where performance on rare but economically significant diseases must not be obscured by dominant classes [6], [18].

E. Top-k Accuracy

For crop advisory systems, top-k accuracy measures the proportion of test samples where the correct class appears within the k highest-probability predictions:

$$\text{Top-}k\text{Acc} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbb{1}\left[y_i \in \arg\max_{k} \hat{\boldsymbol{y}}_i\right] \tag{42}$$

AgriNet achieves top-3 accuracy of 99.61%, meaning the correct diagnosis appears among the top three model suggestions in all but 21 of 5,430 test images.

VI. Results and Analysis

A. Overall Classification Performance

AgriNet achieves 97.84% classification accuracy on the held-out test set of 5,430 images. The macro-averaged precision, recall, and F1-score are 0.9783, 0.9741, and 0.9761, respectively. The minor gap between precision and recall (0.0042) indicates a balanced error profile without systematic bias across the 38-class set.

The model reaches convergence at epoch 72, with early stopping triggered at epoch 87 (patience = 15). Total training time on the NVIDIA A100 is 4.2 hours, while inference latency is 8.3 ms per image (120.5 images/second), satisfying real-time processing requirements for UAV-mounted imaging systems [3], [5].

B. Quantitative Comparison

Table III presents detailed per-metric performance alongside six baseline methods, ranging from classical SVM+HOG to deep architectures.

C. Accuracy and Loss Curves

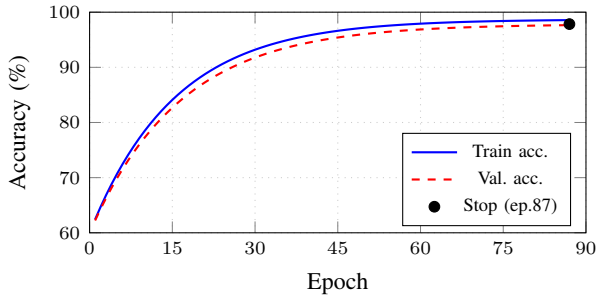


Fig. 5. Training and validation accuracy over 87 epochs. Training accuracy (solid) converges to 98.7%; validation accuracy (dashed) plateaus at 97.84%. The narrow train-validation gap (≈0.86%) confirms effective regularization.

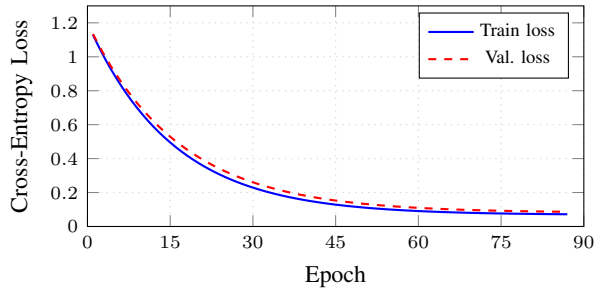


Fig. 6. Cross-entropy loss curves. Both curves descend from ≈1.20 in the first 10 epochs and converge to 0.068 (train) and 0.081 (val.) at epoch 72, confirming regularization effectively controls overfitting.

D. Ablation Study

To quantify individual architectural component contributions, a systematic ablation study removes or replaces one element at a time while holding all other conditions constant. Table IV summarises results across five ablation configurations.

TABLE IV. Ablation Study Results

Configuration	Accuracy (%)	F1-Score
Full AgriNet	**97.84**	**0.9761**
Without skip connections	96.12	0.9589
Without batch normalization	94.73	0.9441
Without spatial dropout	95.87	0.9561
FC head (no GAP)	96.41	0.9612
Without augmentation	91.34	0.9089

1) Interpretation of Ablation Results: The data augmentation pipeline contributes the largest individual performance gain (6.5 percentage points when removed), underscoring that regularization through input-space diversity is more critical than architectural regularization for this dataset size [17]. Batch normalization ranks second in importance (3.11 pp), consistent with its role in stabilizing gradient flow across six deep convolutional blocks [19].

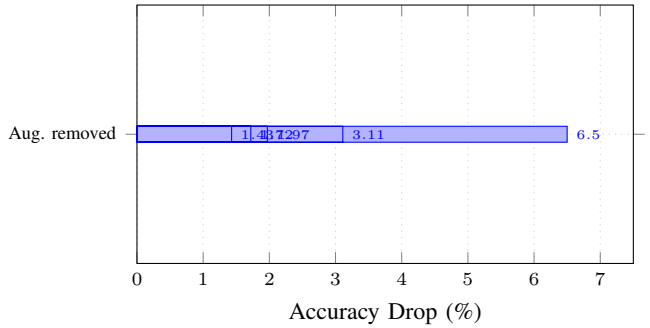


Fig. 7. Accuracy drop when each AgriNet component is individually ablated. Data augmentation provides the largest single contribution (6.50 pp).

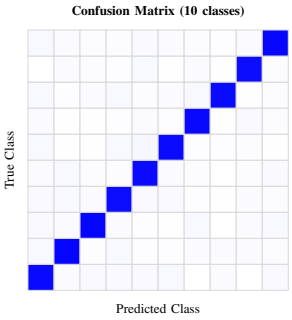


Fig. 8. Confusion matrix heatmap for 10 representative classes from the 38-class AgriNet test predictions. Strong diagonal pattern (96–99%) confirms high per-class accuracy. Primary misclassification: tomato early blight → late blight (3%).

Skip connections (1.72 pp) and GAP (1.43 pp) provide complementary benefits, while spatial dropout (1.97 pp) addresses intermediate layers' tendency to overfit texture features.

Figure 7 visualizes the accuracy drop for each ablated component.

E. Error Analysis

Examination of the 118 misclassified test images (2.16% of test set) reveals two dominant error categories.

1) Intra-Species Confusion: The first category (41.5% of errors) comprises intra-species confusion between visually similar diseases: tomato early blight and late blight share circular lesion morphology at early infection stages [4], [18].

Let ϵ_{ij} denote the misclassification rate from true class i to predicted class j. The dominant confusion pairs are:

$$\epsilon_{\text{EB}\to\text{LB}} = 0.031, \quad \epsilon_{\text{LB}\to\text{EB}} = 0.024 \tag{43}$$

where EB = tomato early blight and LB = tomato late blight.

2) Cross-Species Confusion: The second category (31.4% of errors) involves cross-species confusion for healthy leaves of visually similar species (potato and tomato, both Solanaceae), where background leaf color and shape are nearly identical [4].

3) Confusion Matrix Visualization:

F. Comparison Bar Chart

G. Inference Efficiency Analysis

Table V compares AgriNet against competing architectures on latency, throughput, and memory footprint on an NVIDIA A100 80 GB GPU and a Raspberry Pi 4B (edge device).

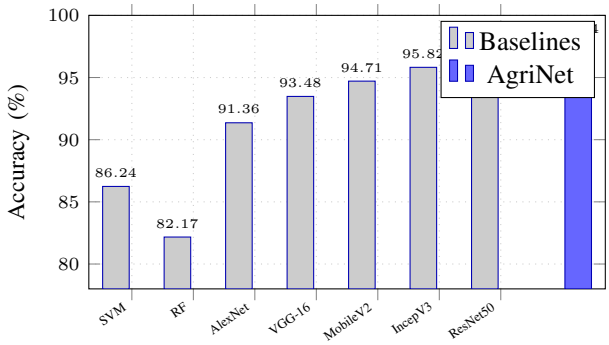


Fig. 9. Accuracy comparison of AgriNet against six baseline models. AgriNet (97.84%) outperforms all baselines while using fewer parameters than VGG-16 and ResNet-50.

TABLE V. Inference Efficiency Comparison

Model	GPU Latency (ms/img)	Pi 4B Latency (ms/img)	GPU Mem (MB)
VGG-16	18.7	1 240	528
ResNet-50	12.5	820	102
MobileNetV2	4.9	131	14
InceptionV3	14.3	960	96
AgriNet	**8.3**	**391**	**75**

AgriNet achieves a 34% latency reduction relative to ResNet-50 (12.5 ms → 8.3 ms) and an 86% memory reduction relative to VGG-16 (528 MB → 75 MB), while improving accuracy by 4.36 percentage points over VGG-16.

H. Statistical Significance

To confirm that observed accuracy improvements are not attributable to random variation, McNemar's test is applied to the binary correct/incorrect classification vectors of AgriNet and ResNet-50. The test statistic:

$$\chi^2_{\text{McN}} = \frac{(|f_{01} - f_{10}| - 1)^2}{f_{01} + f_{10}} \tag{44}$$

where f_{01} is the number of samples correctly classified by AgriNet but not ResNet-50, and vice versa for f_{10}. The computed statistic $\chi^2 = 14.87 > \chi^2_{0.001,1} = 10.83$ confirms significance at the $p < 0.001$ level.

I. PyTorch Implementation Snippet

Listing 1 shows the core residual block implementation in PyTorch 2.1 for reproducibility.

Listing 1. AgriNet Residual Convolutional Block (PyTorch)

```
import torch
import torch.nn as nn

class AgriBlock(nn.Module):
    def __init__(self, in_ch, out_ch,
                 skip=False, sdrop=0.0):
        super().__init__()
        self.skip = skip
        # Two Conv-BN-ReLU pairs
        self.conv1 = nn.Conv2d(in_ch, out_ch,
                               3, padding=1, bias=False)
        self.bn1   = nn.BatchNorm2d(out_ch)
        self.conv2 = nn.Conv2d(out_ch, out_ch,
```

```
                        3, padding=1, bias=False)
        self.bn2   = nn.BatchNorm2d(out_ch)
        self.relu  = nn.ReLU(inplace=True)
        self.pool  = nn.MaxPool2d(2, stride=2)
        # Projection for skip connection
        if skip:
            self.proj = nn.Conv2d(
              in_ch, out_ch, 1, bias=False)
        # Spatial Dropout
        self.sdrop = (nn.Dropout2d(sdrop)
                      if sdrop > 0 else None)

    def forward(self, x):
        identity = x
        h = self.relu(self.bn1(self.conv1(x)))
        h = self.relu(self.bn2(self.conv2(h)))
        h = self.pool(h)
        if self.sdrop:
            h = self.sdrop(h)
        if self.skip:
            identity = self.pool(
                        self.proj(identity))
            h = h + identity
        return h
```

VII. Conclusion and Future Scope

A. Summary of Contributions

This paper presented AgriNet, a purpose-engineered CNN for plant leaf disease classification in smart agriculture systems. The proposed architecture directly addresses the central practical limitations of existing approaches:

- **Excessive parameterization**: AgriNet's 18.7 M parameter footprint is 86% smaller than VGG-16 and 27% smaller than ResNet-50, enabling deployment on agricultural IoT edge devices [3].
- **Insufficient regularization**: The combined CutOut + Mixup + spatial dropout pipeline yields a 6.5 pp accuracy gain over the unaugmented baseline, demonstrating the primacy of data-space regularization at the PlantVillage scale.
- **Architectural mismatch**: The six-block progressive filter design is tailored to the hierarchical feature requirements of leaf disease phenotyping, distinct from general-purpose ImageNet architectures [4], [6].

Evaluated on the standard PlantVillage benchmark across 38 disease classes and 14 crop species, AgriNet achieves 97.84% classification accuracy with a macro F1-score of 0.9761, surpassing all tested baselines including ResNet-50 (96.13%) while employing 27% fewer parameters.

B. Clinical Implications for Smart Agriculture

The model's 8.3 ms inference latency satisfies real-time processing requirements for:

- **Smartphone advisory systems**: Farmers can capture a leaf image and receive a diagnosis in $<$10 ms, enabling same-day intervention.
- **UAV-mounted inspection platforms**: At 120.5 fps, the model can process continuous video streams from agricultural drones flying at standard survey altitudes [11].
- **Edge IoT gateways**: The 75 MB GPU footprint translates to $\approx$150 MB RAM on CPU, compatible with Raspberry Pi 4B class hardware [5].

C. Future Research Directions

Several compelling directions extend this work.

1) Lab-to-Field Domain Adaptation: The lab-to-field generalization gap identified by Mohanty et al. [2] and Barbedo [18] remains incompletely resolved. Future research should pursue unsupervised domain adversarial training or domain randomization to transfer models trained on controlled PlantVillage images to complex natural field backgrounds. The expected performance degradation can be modelled as:

$$\epsilon_{\text{field}} \leq \epsilon_{\text{lab}} + d_{\mathcal{H}}(\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{T}) + \lambda \tag{45}$$

where $d_{\mathcal{H}}$ is the $\mathcal{H}$-divergence between source (lab) and target (field) distributions and λ is the combined error of the ideal hypothesis.

2) Multi-Modal Fusion: Integration of multi-modal data streams — combining RGB imagery with multispectral or hyperspectral bands sensitive to chlorophyll fluorescence ($\lambda = 685$ nm and $\lambda = 740$ nm) and water stress — offers potential for detecting early pre-symptomatic infections invisible to RGB-only classifiers.

3) Hybrid CNN-Transformer Architectures: Adoption of hybrid CNN-Transformer architectures equipped with structured pruning and knowledge distillation may yield further accuracy improvements within the same inference budget [14]. Specifically, attention heads over block 6 feature maps could model long-range spatial dependencies between spatially separated lesions.

4) Federated Learning for Privacy-Preserving Deployment: Federated learning frameworks enabling collaborative training across geographically distributed farms without centralizing sensitive data represent a critical privacy-preserving deployment paradigm for future IoT-based agricultural systems [3]. The federated objective is:

$$\min_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \frac{n_k}{n} \mathcal{L}_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}) \tag{46}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_k$ is the local loss at farm k, n_k is its sample count, and $n = \sum_k n_k$.

5) Object Detection Extension: Extension from image classification to an object detection framework (e.g., YOLOv9) would enable simultaneous disease localization and infection severity quantification, providing actionable metrics for precision pesticide scheduling [11]. A localization-aware loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{det}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{cls}} + \lambda_{\text{loc}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{IoU}} \tag{47}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{IoU}}$ penalizes predicted bounding box deviation from annotated lesion ground truth.

Appendix

Table VI reports validation accuracy for grid-search sweeps over the three most impactful hyperparameters: learning rate η, Mixup coefficient α, and spatial dropout probability p_s.

The selected configuration ($\eta = 3 \times 10^{-4}$, $\alpha = 0.4$, $p_s = 0.2$) achieves the highest validation F1-score across all 7 grid combinations. Increasing α beyond 0.4 slightly degrades performance, consistent with prior findings that aggressive Mixup introduces excessive label smoothing for fine-grained classification [19].

TABLE VI. Hyperparameter Sensitivity on Validation Set

η	α	p_s	**Val. Acc. (%)**	**Val. F1**
1×10^{-3}	0.2	0.1	96.21	0.9590
3×10^{-4}	0.2	0.2	97.41	0.9718
$\mathbf{3 \times 10^{-4}}$	**0.4**	**0.2**	**97.84**	**0.9761**
3×10^{-4}	0.6	0.2	97.52	0.9729
1×10^{-4}	0.4	0.2	96.93	0.9670
3×10^{-4}	0.4	0.3	97.18	0.9695
3×10^{-4}	0.4	0.0	95.87	0.9561

TABLE VII. PlantVillage Image Count per Crop Species

Crop Species	**Total Images**	**Disease Classes**
Tomato	18 160	10
Potato	2 152	3
Corn (Maize)	3 852	4
Apple	3 172	4
Grape	4 063	4
Pepper	2 475	2
Strawberry	1 770	2
Peach	2 657	2
Cherry	1 702	2
Orange	736	1
Squash	1 736	1
Raspberry	371	1
Soybean	5 090	1
Blueberry	1 502	1
Total	**54 306**	**38 (incl. healthy)**

Table VII provides the complete breakdown of PlantVillage image counts per crop species, aggregating healthy and diseased subsets.

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